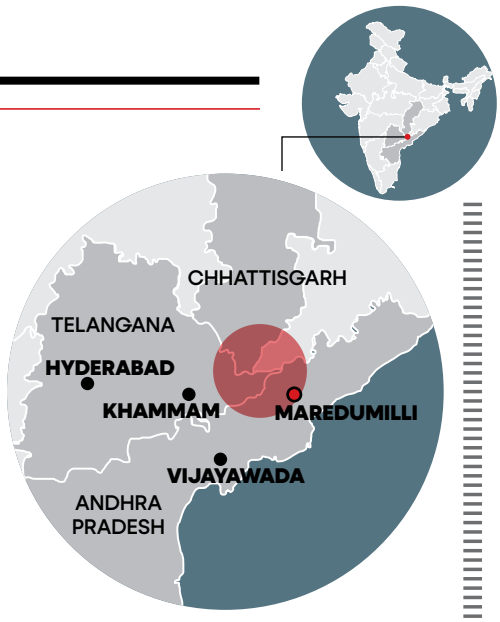
gus, but Chhattisgarh was the centre of the 'liberated zone' they had carved out in central India, the heart of the insurrection. It's also where it's fast running out of breath. Hidma, 50, was the only Chhattisgarh tribal to have ever made it to the central committee of the banned CPI (Maoist). He met his end in the Alluri Sitharama Raju district of Andhra Pradesh.

When AP Police gunned down Hidma on November 18, with his wife Raje and four other cadres, what ended was a decades-long hunt—for the most ruthless and accomplished fighter in the Maoist ranks. Hidma



SHRUNK HAVEN Hidma was killed in Maredumilli, near the Andhra-Telangana-Chhattisgarh tri-junction

Takeaways

- **Madvi Hidma, 50, the most wanted Maoist guerrilla, is killed in a gunfight in AP**
- **The only Chhattisgarh tribal in the Maoist top ranks, Hidma had led many lethal strikes**
- **Chhattisgarh was seeking his surrender, with Dy CM Sharma trying via his mother**
- **But an intense manhunt was on too, which saw Hidma escape to AP—his Waterloo**

is said to have scripted and executed over two dozen of the most audacious and bloody attacks on security forces in Chhattisgarh in the past decade and a half. These included the Tadmetla attack in 2010 that left 76 CRPF troopers dead and the Tarrem ambush in 2021 (toll: 22 security personnel dead, 31 injured). He carried a reward of Rs 1.8 crore collectively in Maoist-affected states, including Chhattisgarh, MP, AP, Telangana, Maharashtra and Odisha.

HUNTER AND PREY

Born in Puvarti village in Sukma district, Hidma studied till class 5 in a local school and joined the Maoists as a Bal Sangham member in 1991. He worked in Balaghat in MP, in Odisha and united Andhra, acquiring a fresh name wherever he went. A blend of ruthless tactics, bravado, organisational and risk-taking ability saw him rise through the ranks, heading the dreaded Battalion No. 1 of the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army in 2009-10. But those halcyon days were winding down. Till 2024, Puvarti was part of a 'security vacuum' zone. Last year, the CRPF established a camp there. They called it 'The Farm'. It was in Puvarti that cereals and veggies were cultivated for Maoists. They had even built a check dam there.

There is bound to be heartburn in Chhattisgarh over AP bagging the 'trophy'. Since December 2023, Chhattisgarh Police had closed in on him many times. Every time, he would manage to evade the ambush, adding to the legend of his invincibility. In end-October, they had him in the cross hairs during an operation on the Telangana border. Hidma managed to slip out yet again. The old Maoist bosses, of whom only Devji is left now, had hopes for the insurgency as long as Hidma was at large. That horizon is now at a vanishing point. ■



By **Jeemon Jacob**

THEY ARE CALLING IT THE 'SEMI-FINAL' in Kerala, the local self-government (LSG) polls scheduled for December 9 and 11. The CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front and the Congress-led United Democratic Front are the traditional battlers, but the BJP, riding on the momentum of the stupendous win in Bihar, is hoping to stage a few surprises. It has certainly been prepping for it—way back in late July, the state unit led by ex-Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar had activated a 100-day 'Mission Countdown 2025' clock in all district offices, targeting the poll.

That was just the beginning. Membership and voter enrolment drives, party workshops, new ward committees—it's been a busy three months. In the 2020 LSG polls, the BJP had won a modest 10 village panchayats (out of the total 941) but also two key municipalities, Palakkad and Pandalam. More importantly, they finished second in two of the five corporations—Kollam and capital Thiruvananthapuram. This time around, they are pulling